The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Pete Hegseth, America's defence chief, said that Tuesday would be the "most intense day of strikes inside **Iran**". The statement follows mixed messages from **Donald Trump** in the past 24 hours, as he claimed that the war would be over "very soon" and that it was "very complete, pretty much", even as he vowed to "go further" if Iran continued to block oil supplies.

Amin Nasser, the boss of **Saudi Aramco**—the world's largest oil producer—, said the disruption caused by Iran's closure of the Strait of Hormuz had resulted in "the biggest crisis the region's oil and gas industry has faced". The company said it would be able to ship 70% of its normal volumes as it increases exports through Yanbu, a port on the Red Sea.

The **Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps**, the Iranian regime's security forces, said only it would decide when to end the war. It also warned that it would not allow "one litre of oil" to be exported from the region until the attacks stopped. Meanwhile thousands of Iranians rallied in support of Mojtaba Khamenei, their new supreme leader, even as America and Israel continued their bombardment.

China's exports grew by 21.8% during the first two months of 2026, compared with a year earlier, boosting an economy marked by stubborn deflation and weak domestic demand. Growth was 6.6% in December. (China combines January and February figures to smooth the effect of the Spring Festival.) A growing trade surplus will irk Mr Trump as he prepares to meet Xi Jinping later this month.

Authorities in **New Mexico** began searching a **ranch** that belonged to Jeffrey Epstein and was an alleged site of the dead financier's sexual abuse and trafficking. America's Department of Justice said it was reopening a 2019 investigation into the so-called "Zorro Ranch" in February. The 4,000-hectare property outside Santa Fe had not been searched before, according to the *Guardian*, a British newspaper.

Live Nation, a concert promoter that owns Ticketmaster, reached a preliminary agreement with America's DOJ. The department had sought to break up the firm, alleging that it "suffocates" competition. Live Nation swallowed $280m in damages and agreed to allow venues to use multiple vendors to sell tickets, among other measures. Several litigant states did not join the deal, claiming it benefited Live Nation.

Alexander Butterfield, President Richard Nixon's aide during the Watergate scandal, died aged 99. Mr Butterfield oversaw the setup of the taping system Nixon installed in the White House. Those tapes—which Mr Butterfield later revealed to a senate committee investigating the break-in at the Democratic National Headquarters—served as important evidence in the scandal that toppled the president.

Figure of the day: 85%, the proportion of self-described MAGA Republicans who support America's attacks on Iran. Read the full story.

Photograph: Getty Images

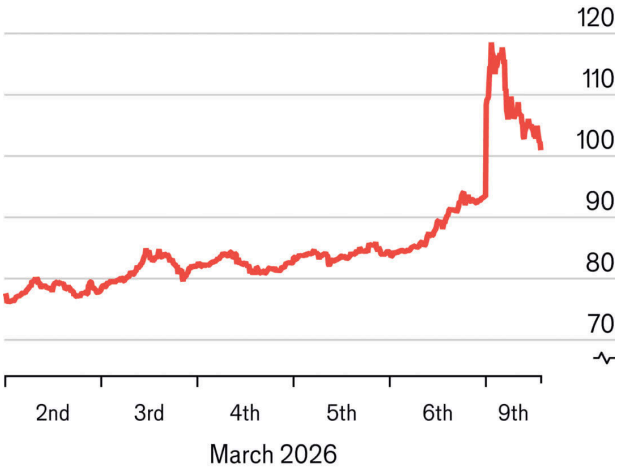
Saudi Aramco’s temporary advantage

Aramco released its full-year results on Tuesday, which revealed that profits at Saudi Arabia’s state-owned oil giant had fallen by 12% to $105bn. But investors were most interested in what has happened since February 28th when America and Israel began attacking Iran.

The firm’s share price has soared in the face of a severe oil shock, but Amin Nasser, Aramco’s boss, warned that the war could have “catastrophic consequences”. His firm already felt some pain. An Iranian drone strike shut down its biggest Saudi Arabian refinery; the company has reduced its output. But the world’s largest oil producer is better equipped to cope with the near-closure of the Strait of Hormuz than its competitors, and has begun rerouting shipments via the Red Sea. Meanwhile state energy companies in Bahrain, Kuwait and Qatar have triggered *force majeure* clauses, releasing them from liability for failure to meet existing contracts. For now, Aramco’s sheer scale is a buffer.

Slippery slope

Brent crude oil price, $ per barrel



Source: LSEG Workspace

Photograph: IMAGO

Germany seeks closer trade ties with America

German trade figures ended on a high note in 2025. Those year-end gains did not carry over into 2026. Exports were down by 2.3% compared with December, and imports slumped by 5.9%, according to the latest trade figures published by Destatis, the German statistics agency.

Last year China overtook America as Germany's biggest trading partner (a position it briefly lost to America in 2024). Bilateral trade between the countries amounted to $285bn, with a record deficit of $101bn for Germany. Uncertainty over erratic tariff policies caused exports to America to fall to €146.2bn, a 9.4% drop from the previous year. Germany still maintained a trade surplus with America of €51.9bn in 2025, but this was down from €69.6bn in 2024. German policymakers are eager to diversify away from China. They want deeper ties with America—even if America has other ideas.

Photograph: AP

Javier Milei showcases a transformed Argentina

On Tuesday Javier Milei, the president of Argentina, will speak at a glitzy event in New York as part of “Argentina week”, intended to drum up investment. He will probably boast about overhauling the country’s economy: inflation is down, growth is up and his government has passed stacks of legislation since 2023. That, Mr Milei is sure to point out, has created new opportunities to make big bucks in Argentina, from mining to data centres. Some new deals may even be announced.

Yet headwinds remain. There are still some capital controls in place, making it difficult to get money out. Meanwhile the potential return to power of the populist Peronist opposition at some point is a worry for any long-term investor. Mixed signals from the administration don’t help. Mr Milei’s government wants new investments but, in a recent U-turn, said it would not borrow from global capital markets to finance itself. (Interest rates would be too high, it argues.) The big event—in the heart of Wall Street—might suggest otherwise.

Photograph: Netflix

“One Piece” sails back

Netflix released the second season of “One Piece”, its adaptation of a Japanese manga and anime series, on Tuesday. The first season—which follows a ragtag crew of pirates—was the streaming giant’s most-watched show in the second half of 2023. The protagonists’ grinning skull-and-crossbones flag became a symbol of courage in the face of corrupt power at Gen Z protests in Nepal, Madagascar and other countries last year. New episodes will be shown at cinemas in North America and Japan.

Such popularity is unusual. Western live-action anime adaptations typically do terribly: “Dragonball Evolution” was a box-office disaster in 2009; Netflix rapidly cancelled “Cowboy Bebop” after one season in 2021. “One Piece” has succeeded by staying faithful to its source material—Oda Eiichiro, the original creator, oversees the Netflix show too. And its diverse casting has been well received by viewers. For an industry eyeing anime’s vast fanbase, “One Piece” may have finally charted the right course.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily Quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: Which William Somerset Maugham novel features a cholera epidemic in China?

Monday: Which was the second and last Bond film to feature Timothy Dalton?

There is no greater misfortune in the world than the loss of reason.

Mikhail Bulgakov